

once as otherwise White could prevent the manoeuvre with h4-h5.

26 Bxg5 Be8 27 f4

White allows the opening of the long diagonal in order to get some vague attacking chances of his own against the black king. The best chance was 27 Qf5 as after 27...Bg6 28 Qe6+ Kh8 29 Bf6 Bxc2 30 Bxg7+ Kxg7 31 Qe7+ White scrambles a draw by perpetual check. Black shouldn't be so greedy. With 28...Bf7 29 Qf5 c6! his big centre gives him the better prospects.

27...exf4 28 Qxf4 Bxc3!

This is not the sort of move one should play lightly and I didn't. I used up most of my remaining time making sure there would be no nasty surprises on the weakened dark squares around my king.

29 bxc3 Qxa3+ 30 Kd2 Rxc3!? (Diagram 6)

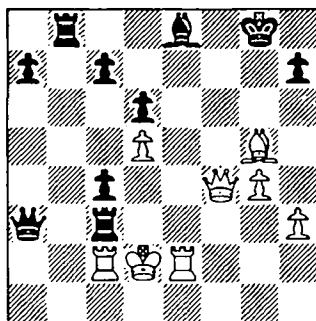


Diagram 6

Black keeps things simple

This is actually the safest move in the position as with best play it leads to a very favourable endgame.

31 Rxe8+?

The main line was 31 Rxc3 Rb2+ 32 Rc2 (32 Kd1 Ba4+ 33 Rcc2 Rb1+) 32...Rxc2+ 33 Kxc2 Qd3+ 34 Kc1 Qxe2 35 Bh6 Qe7 which should be winning for Black.

31...Rxe8 32 Rxc3 Qa2+! 33 Rc2

Or 33 Kd1 Qe2+ 34 Kc1 Qe1+ 35 Kc2 Re2+ and Black wins.

33...Qa5!+ 34 Rc3 Qxd5+ 35 Kc1 Re1+ 36 Kb2 Qb5+ 37 Ka2 Re2+ White resigns

Game 60

□ Agrest ■ Milov

European Championship, Ohrid 2001

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 h3 0-0 6 Bg5 Na6 7 Bd3 e5 8

d5 Qc8 9 g4 Nd7 10 a3 Nac5!?

Bareev once crushed me from this position after I decided to ignore the threat of b2-b4 in order to exchange off my bad bishop. After 10...f5 11 b4 f4 12 Bh4 Bf6 13 Bxf6 Nxf6 14 Nf3 c5?! 15 dxc6 bxc6 16 c5! the position had opened in White's favour. However, the solid 14...Qe7 would not have been so bad.

11 Bc2 a5 12 Nge2

12 b4 must be the critical test of Black's strategy. White probably felt it was premature to open the queenside with most of his kingside still at home. After 12...axb4 13 axb4 Rxa1 14 Qxa1 Na6 15 Qa3 I'm not quite sure what Milov had in mind. Most likely something violent based on ...f7-f5 and ...e5-e4, even at the cost of material.

12...Nb6! (Diagram 7)

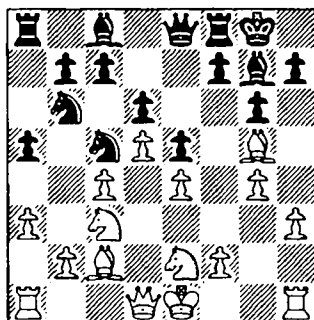


Diagram 7

Rules are made to be broken

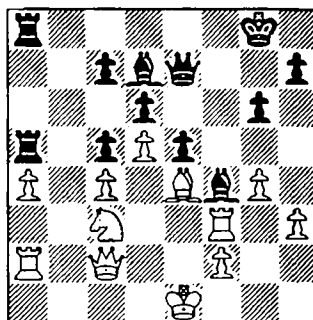


Diagram 8

Black can play on at no risk



WARNING: Do not move your knights to b6 in the King's Indian.

Confused by the '!'. Is it a misprint? No, just one of the exceptions that prove the rule. In general b6 is a very passive square for a knight in the King's Indian but here Black gains a tempo by attacking the pawn on c4. This tempo gives him the time to play ...f7-f5.

13 b3 f5 14 Rg1 fxe4 15 Nxe4 Nxe4 16 Bxe4 a4!

Black derives maximum benefit from the unusual position of his knight on b6. White's queenside structure will now be spoiled.

17 Nc3 axb3 18 Qxb3 Nd7 19 Be3 b6 20 Ra2 Qe7 21 Rg3 Nc5

This is such a good square for the knight that White feels obliged to give up his strong bishop for it. He then gets an outside passed pawn but it is not clear if this pawn is weak or strong.

22 Bxc5 bxc5 23 a4 Bh6 24 Ne2 Bd7 25 Qc2 Bf4 26 Rf3 Ra5 27 Nc3 Rfa8 (Diagram 8) Draw agreed

I would have been tempted to continue with Black.

White Plays 6 Nf3

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 h3 0-0 6 Nf3

The move order 5 Nf3 0-0 6 h3 is at least as common.

6...e5

There are several move orders Black can employ to reach the desired set-up. Most of them converge after a few moves. For example, 6...Na6 7 Bg5 e5 8 d5 takes us into Game 61.

7 d5

7 dxe5 dxe5 8 Qxd8 Rxd8 9 Bg5 Re8 is very similar to Game 1. The fact that White has played h2-h3 instead of Be2 hardly makes any difference. You already know what I think about that variation.

7...Na6 (Diagram 9)

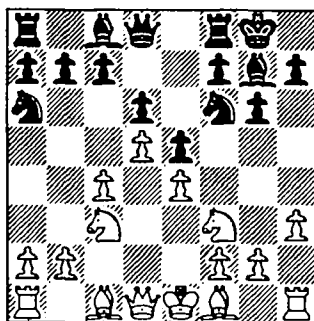


Diagram 9

White has a choice with the bishop

White has to decide where he is going to develop his queen's bishop. In Games 61 and 62 he plays 8 Bg5 while in Game 63 he plays 8 Be3.

Theoretical?

Whilst theoretical knowledge always helps this is not one of the more bookish lines. There is plenty of scope for original play.

Statistics

After 6 Nf3 White has scored 57% from 3175 games. When White plays 8 Bg5 (from Diagram 9) he scores heavily at 63% while with 8 Be3 he has scored only 47%. Krasenkov, perhaps the leading exponent of this line with the white pieces has scored a whopping 83% from 59 games. I think I'll play the Queen's Gambit next time I play him.

Illustrative Games

Game 61

□ Krasenkov ■ Andonovski

Panormo 2001

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 h3 e5 7 d5 Na6 8 Bg5 Qe8 9 g4 Nd7!?

For a discussion about the ideas behind the last couple of moves, see the introduction to 6 Bg5

10 Rg1 Kh8

Black must remove his king from the g-file before playing ...f7-f5.

11 a3!?

This motif of locking the knight on a6 out of the game is extremely well known from similar positions (see games 59 and 60) but is actually a novelty here. The normal White plan is 11 Qd2 Ndc5 and now either Nh4 to prevent ...f7-f5, or 12 0-0-0, allowing it but hoping to get play on the kingside

11...f5 12 gxf5 gxf5 13 b4 (Diagram 10)

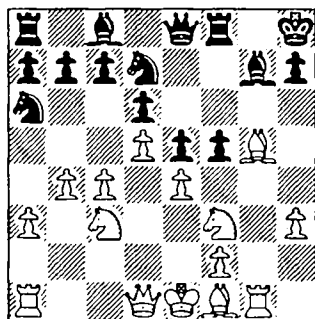


Diagram 10

Locking out the knight on a6

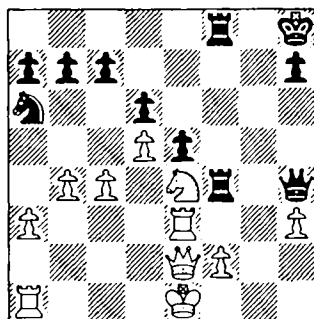


Diagram 11

Black to play What is best?

13...Nf6

The game now revolves around the battle for the crucial e4-square. If White can maintain a blockade here he will have a good position. On the other hand, if Black can break the blockade and force through ...e4 the white king would be in for a torrid time.

14 Bd3 Nxe4 15 Nxe4 fxe4 16 Bxe4 Bf5 17 Nd2 Qg6!

A good move. Not only does Black threaten to take on e4 but also 18...h6 as the bishop on g5 is pinned. Krasenkov finds an imaginative solution.

18 Rg4! Qh5?

Oh dear, this is just hopeless. Black just heads straight for a terrible endgame. The one thing he shouldn't do in this position is exchange queens as then the white king no longer has any worries. Black should also avoid 18...Bxg4? 19 Qxg4 Qf7 20 Qh4 Qg8 21 Ke2 followed by Rg1. White has a light square bind and a dangerous attack.

The right move is 18...Bh6! which forces the exchange of Black's passive bishop for White's active one. After something like 19 Bxh6? Qxh6 20 Bxf5 Rxf5 21 Rg3 Raf8 22 Ne4 Rf4 23 Qe2 Qh4 24 Re3 (Diagram 11) White has maintained his blockade of e4 but Black has taken control of the dark squares, and in particular the f4-square.

Exercise 10: What should Black play now?

Instead of 19 Bxh6? Krasenkov would certainly have played 19 h4!. After 19...Bxg4 20 Qxg4 Qg7 he still has good compensation for the exchange but less than after 18...Bxg4 as now Black can exchange off the dark-squared bishops.

19 Rg3 Qxd1+ 20 Rxd1 Bd7 21 Ke2 Rf7 22 Rdg1 Raf8 23 Be3 b6 24 Nf3

The difference in activity between the opposing pieces is quite striking. What is that knight doing on a6?

24...Bf5 25 Bxf5 Rxf5 26 Ng5! Re8 Black resigns

The simplest way to win is 27 Ne6 Bf6 28 Bh6! with the devastating, and unstoppable, threat of Bf8.

Game 62

□ J.Ivanov ■ V.Georgiev

Salou 2000

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 h3 e5 7 d5 Na6 8 Bg5 h6

With 8 Bg5 White was actively encouraging this move which is often a liability for Black in the King's Indian.

9 Be3 Nc5 10 Nd2 a5 11 g4

A quieter line is 11 Be2 Bd7 12 0-0 (12 g4 would of course transpose into the main game) 12...Nh7!? with ...f7-f5 to follow.

11...c6

A useful rule of thumb in these lines is to play ...c7-c6 only in reply to White's g2-g4. After g2-g4 White's king won't be very safe on the kingside so he will usually be looking to castle long. It is therefore a good idea for Black to be ready to open lines in this sector of the board at a moment's notice. Playing ...c7-c6 is quite safe but Black must be more careful about taking on d5. If he mistimes this then the white pieces may become very active. A second rule of thumb for Black, therefore, is to only play ...cxd5 when he can follow up with ...b7-b5.

12 Be2 Bd7 (Diagram 12)

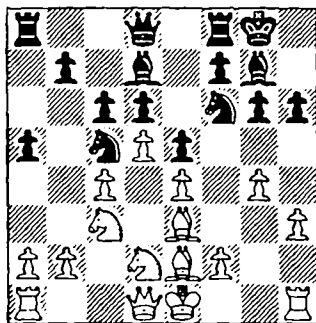


Diagram 12

Black prepares queenside play

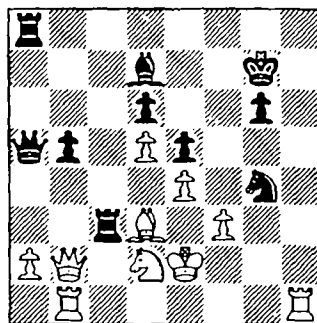


Diagram 13

Black attacks on both flanks

The plan is to play ...a5-a4 and ...Qa5 to develop an initiative.

13 h4 a4 14 h5

It is not such a good idea for White to ignore the threat of ...Qa5. However, even after 14 g5 hxg5 15 hxg5 Nh7 16 Nf3 cxd5 17 cxd5 Qa5 18 Qd2 Rfc8 19 Kf1 b5 Black had active play in Akesson-Gallagher, Istanbul Olympiad 2000.

14...Qa5 15 f3 a3!

And this was the other threat. Ideally, White would like to meet this move with 16 b3 but this just loses the knight on c3. By exchanging his a-pawn for White's b-pawn Black gains a positional advantage.

16 Qc2 axb2 17 Qxb2 cxd5 18 cxd5 b5! 19 Rb1

The pawn could not be taken. 19 Nxb5 Rfb8 20 a4 Bxb5! and now 21 axb5 loses a rook and 21 Bxb5 Nd3+, a queen

19...Rfc8

It's not unusual for Black to sacrifice the h6-pawn in the King's Indian. In return he hopes to take control of the dark squares.

20 hxg6 fxg6 21 Bxh6 Nd3+! 22 Bxd3 Rxc3 23 Bxg7 Kxg7 24 Ke2
24 Be2 Rac8 was better but Black has more than enough for the pawn.

24...Nxg4! (Diagram 13) 25 Qb4

After 25 fxg4 Bxg4+ the only move not to lose the piece back at once is 26 Ke3 but then 26...Qb6! is mate.

25...Rxd3! 26 fxg4

26 Qxa5 Re3+! 27 Kf1 Rxa5 28 fxg4 Rxa2 is an even worse endgame.

26...Qxb4 27 Rxb4 Rg3 28 Rb2 Rf8 29 Kd1 Bxg4+ 30 Kc1 Rc8+ 31
Kb1 Be2 32 Re1 Bd3+ 33 Ka1 Rg2 34 Nb3 Rxb2 35 Kxb2 Rc4
White resigns

White loses a second pawn. An excellent game from Black.

Game 63

□ Kavalek ■ Kasparov

Bugojno 1982

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 h3 e5 7 d5 Na6 8 Be3

This time White doesn't bother to try and tempt ...h7-h6 out of Black but develops his bishop directly to e3.

8...Nh5

Black prepares ...f7-f5 in the most active fashion. This is the line that has put most White players off playing 8 Be3. The line with ...Nh5 is less good with a pawn on h6 (8 Bg5 h6 9 Be3 Nh5) as at some point White can gain an important tempo with Qd2.

The plan that Black used in Game 62 is also playable here. After 8...Nc5 9 Nd2 a5 10 g4 c6 11 Be2, the position is the same (as in Game 62) except for the fact that Black has a pawn on h7 instead of h6. This seemingly insignificant difference is enough to make the way Black played in the previous game unattractive (11...Bd7 12 g5!), but at the same time introduces a new possibility that wasn't really available to Black there. After 11 Be2, the Russian Grandmaster Dolmatov has patented the pawn sacrifice 11...a4!. The point is that White has to give up his important dark-squared bishop to win the pawn. Few grandmasters would take White after 12 Bxc5 dxc5 13 Nxa4 Qa5 14 Nc3 Bh6! (note this last move wouldn't have been available with a pawn on h6). If White doesn't take the pawn Black plays ...Qa5 with pressure on the queenside.

9 Nh2

This strange-looking move prevents the immediate 9...f5 as after 10 exf5 Black can no longer recapture with the pawn. That explains the thinking behind Black's next move.

9...Qe8 10 Be2 Nf4

10...f5 is a major alternative which Kasparov has also played. Black's main idea is to meet 11 exf5 with 11...Nf4 when White should settle for the roughly level position that arises after 12 0-0 Bxf5 rather than risk 12 Bxf4 exf4 13 fxg6 Qxg6 14 Kf1 Nc5 when Black has excellent compensation for the pawn.

11 Bf3 f5 12 h4?!

White's ambitious strategy is based on playing g3 to expel the knight (12 g3 Nxf3 is good for Black) but this is too risky with his king still in the centre. He should have played 12 0-0 with a roughly level game after 12...Nc5.

12...Qe7 13 g3 Nb4! (Diagram 14) 14 Qb3?

Kavalek had no doubt been shocked by Black's previous move but it is suicidal to keep his king in the centre. He had to play 14 0-0 against which Kasparov intended 14...g5!. The white king is certainly not out